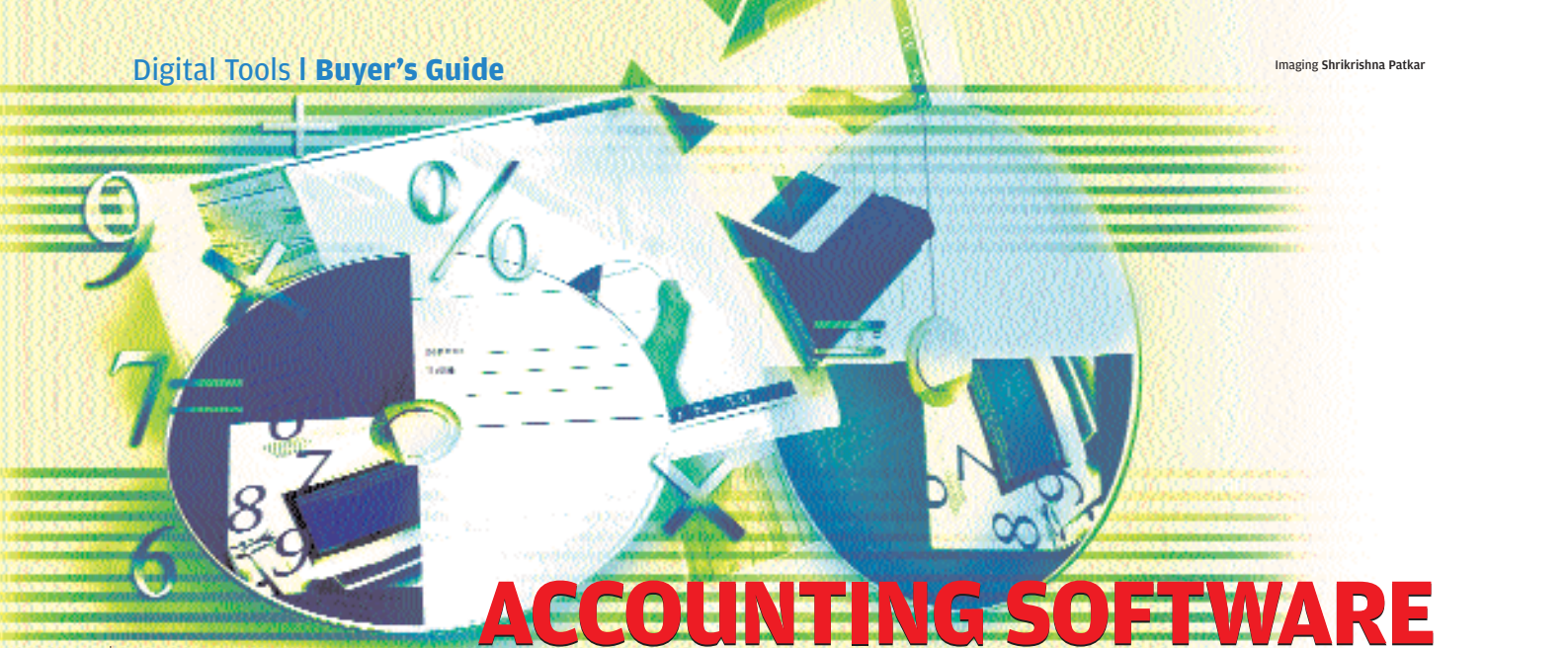




ACCOUNTING SOFTWARE

Every entrepreneur has productivity in mind and using technology to achieve it is definitely not a bad idea—but if the choice and implementation is not done wisely, the same idea can be detrimental to business goals.

Use of accounting software to enhance your business is one such implementation. There are many software available in the market for this purpose, but it is not necessary that a particular package meets your needs. For example, a package could lack expandability. Similarly, the most expensive package may not be the right choice either. There are several questions you need to ask the software vendor before you decide on a software.

Questions to ask the dealer

I want to employ access control to prevent certain users from editing

and/or viewing financial data. Is such a feature available?

This can be very important, and will help you prevent unauthorised access to financial information of your company. Access control can only be applied if the package supports it. A dealer and the manufacturer's support staff are the right people to ask about this feature.

Can the new accounting software import data from the existing software?

While migrating to a new accounting software, you cannot afford to waste time copying reports and data manually from your existing software. Hence, confirm with the dealer, and if possible, verify with experts or the manufacturer's support team about this feature. This can save you a lot of time.

Ensure that the product you buy is 'VAT ready', as this will be a very important inclusion. VAT has been enforced in the Indian market, and you will proba-

bly check for it yourself when you get the bill for the new software!

Will the software run on my current hardware, or will I need an upgrade?

Enquire if any kind of additional hardware or software is needed for the accounting software you want to buy. This need can be upgrading the operat-



ing system from Windows 98 to Windows XP, or a hardware upgrade for better processing capability. ■

Points To Ponder

What are the features or factors of accounting software that I should assess before making the decision to purchase one?

You are expected to have good idea of your business accounting needs, based on which you can analyse the capability, flexibility and expandability of a package. If you are selling a product, it is important that your software be able to track inventory. If you are selling services, the software should have a good client tracking system.

Other than basic accounting required to monitor sales and balance sheets, the rest of the package should include tax reporting, invoicing and pay roll needs. Similarly, the software should also have the feature of expanding with the future needs, for instance, adapting to VAT. Keeping this need in mind, some software manufacturers design their products to include support for upgradation. Features such as supporting ASCII dot-matrix printers,

or exporting data/reports into Microsoft Excel and Adobe PDF formats would be the icing on the cake. An Indian-style accounting software could make your accounting experience easier.

I have a dotcom business. Are there any packages that have 'Web store' integration?

Most packages support offline business structures, and there are a few that facilitate integration for a dotcom business. This feature will help you keep track of your online business transactions and generate the necessary reports with absolute ease.

Are there enough professionals proficient in the software?

People involved in this kind of work are trained to use the most popular software packages—those that are installed in most companies, and tutorials for which are easily available at your nearest computer education centre. So, if you are migrating to a package by another

manufacturer, first cross-check the availability of professionals for it, or just be sure that the learning curve for the new package is not too steep.

Interface usability... how important should that be?

If you are very dependent on the user interface and want everything at the click of a mouse, you should check demos of the product before you buy it.

Should cost be a criterion?

As a businessman, this can be one of your main concerns. There may be a battalion of cheap and perhaps free accounting software available, but they may not support your needs. Compromising on this means compromising on your productivity. It is advisable that you spend the money that your needs demand. Most feature-rich accounting software cost approximately the same, so you can decide based solely on your needs.